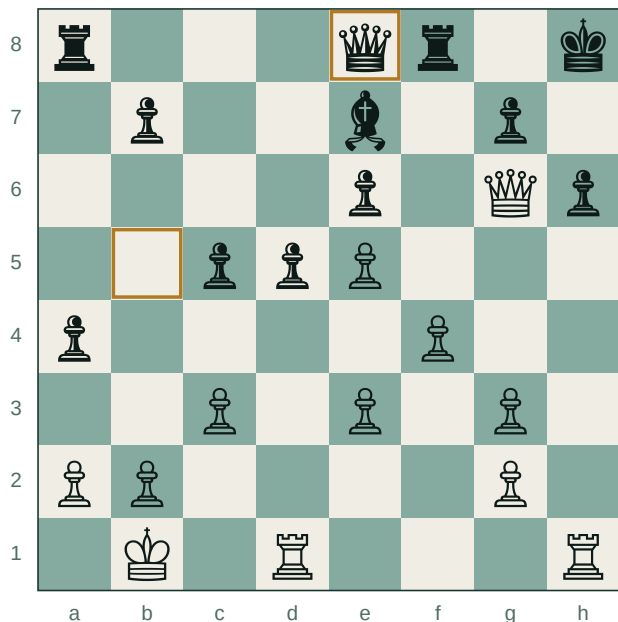


Active defensive resources: White, move 21

Active defensive resources

White to move



Previous move: 20...Qe8. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

21. Rxh6+ gxh6 22. Qxh6+ Kg8 23. Rh1

21.Rxh6+ Check restricts Black to 2 legal replies here. The move also takes the pawn on h6. Recorded reply: **21...gxh6.**

22.Qxh6+ Check restricts Black to 1 legal reply here. From h6 it attacks king on h8 and rook on f8. Recorded reply: **22...Kg8.**

23.Rh1 The rook moves from d1 to h1.

At the end, nominal material is White 22 / Black 27 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, White's balance changes by -3. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does White's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** -3: the balance goes from -2 to -5. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

A defensive puzzle may aim to preserve equality rather than win. Judge success against the threat, not only the final material count.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

The best defense may create a threat, exchange an attacker, or change the geometry of the attack. Identify the opponent's concrete idea before selecting a response.

HOW TO LOOK

Name the threatened move and the conditions it requires. Look for a move that breaks one of those conditions with tempo.

The defending king is on h8. Absolute pin: pawn on h6.